TikTok Fact Checking Training Guide

The Objective

Misinformation is a highly viral and widespread phenomenon across the globe whose reach touches everything from politics to pandemics and has the potential to make a real and sometimes harmful impact in people's lives. Gaining popularity during the 2016 U.S. presidential election, misinformation or "fake news" is a growing issue. In the wake of the COVID-19 pandemic, misinformation has skyrocketed, with almost 80% of consumers reporting that they've seen fake news on the coronavirus outbreak.

Our goal as a team is to get ahead of misinformation and fact check it before it goes viral.

The Team

Lead Stories is an award-winning innovative fact checking and debunking website at the intersection of big data and journalism that developed alongside the need to help combat misinformation. Our mantra has always been "Just Because It's Trending Doesn't Mean It's True." We work quickly to hunt for trending stories, images, videos, and posts that contain false information in order to fact check them and stop the spread of fake news.

We are a signatory of the International Fact Checking Network or IFCN.

The Commitment

Being part of the fact checking team comes with certain responsibilities. Whenever you are engaged in fact checking word for Lead Stories, you must adhere to the following principles:

- Employ impartial journalistic methods and a transparent approach to evidence so that your personal biases do not undermine the accuracy of your work
- Complete fact checks in a timely manner
- Follow IFCN standards when it comes to social media and do not engage in partisan posting
- Back up your fact checks with proper and credible sources
- Keep editors in the loop about any issues that arise or questions you have as soon as possible
- Keep a record of all of your work in your Spreadsheet

The Work

In addition to our debunking work, we partner with social media and networking sites to help slow down the spread of false information on these platforms. Since April 2020 we've provided fact checking related advice and services to ByteDance, the company running TikTok.

We work with fact checkers like you around the world to quickly and accurately help curb fake news in accordance with TikTok community guidelines, which prohibits content that's false or misleading.

The same principles that guide journalism apply to fact checking for this project: a commitment to nonpartisanship, transparency and fairness in which the fact-based evidence dictates our determinations. We do not advocate for or against any policy positions on any issues, nor do we support any political parties or make donations to political organizations. We ask that fact checkers refrain from doing so while under our employ.

The Tools

In order to successfully carry out fact checking services for TikTok, Lead Stories independent fact checkers use a variety of digital tools and platforms. You'll be required to download and proficiently employ them during your time as a fact checker. Here's a rundown of these tools below, followed by the process we use to utilize them.

- **Lark:** This is a communication tool similar to Slack. Joining Lark grants you access to a moderation and fact checking tool called TCS or Task Crowdsourcing, essentially giving you credentials to use TCS.

- **TCS:** This is the platform you'll use to access videos for fact checks. You'll also use this platform to submit your fact checks.

- **Google Docs/Spreadsheets:** Before you submit fact checks in the TCS platform, you'll track them in a Google Doc or Spreadsheet. You'll start a new document every month, which will include the TCS links to the fact check, your determination, notes, as well as any keywords or hashtags that are relevant. You will also need this spreadsheet to process payment.

- **Slack:** You'll get an invitation to be part of the Lead Stories newsroom on Slack, where you can collaborate with your fact checking colleagues. In addition to email, we'll use it to communicate.

The Process

- **Email:** Create a new email address you will exclusively use for Lead Stories. This email address will grant you access to the tools you'll be using and will be an easy and secure way for you to keep track of communication with the Lead Stories team.

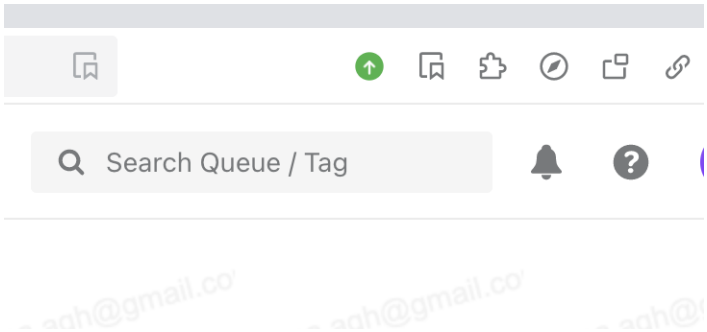
- **Accept Lark Invite & Download:** Before you can access the fact-checking platform TCS, you'll need to sign up for Lark. Please check your email for an invite from Lark and accept it to begin downloading the app.

- **Access TCS URL & Download:** You'll be sent a partner onboarding document as a PDF that contains information from TikTok on how to access TCS. Copy and paste the URL on Page 7 and follow the instructions. For easy access, you can also **click here to begin downloading.**

- **Log Into TCS to Begin Moderating**

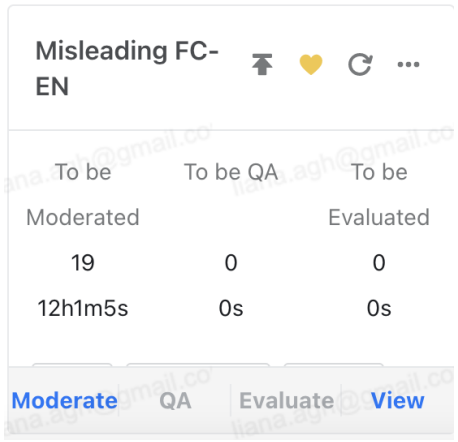
1. **Enter Queue Title**

You'll enter the Queue ID provided to you in the "Search Queue" box



2. **Click Moderate**

Make sure you choose "Moderate" instead of "View."



3. Watch Video

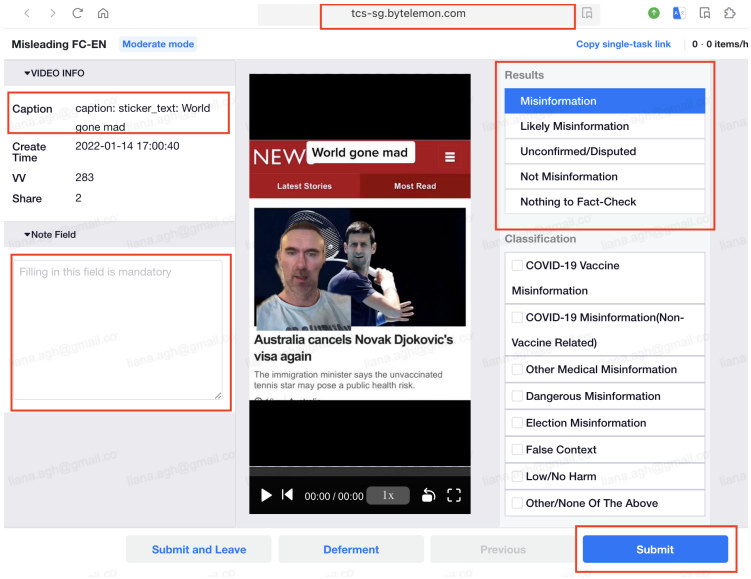
Watch the video in order to make your determination. When making your determination, you should take into account the video as a whole - this includes the caption as well as any text that has been written on top of the video.

4. Prepare a Google Doc/Spreadsheet For Fact Checking

Before you submit your results in TCS, make sure you save the link of the video, your notes (including fact checking links) and your determination in your Google Doc/Spreadsheet that we will send you.

5. Submit

Copy and paste your notes from your saved Google Doc into the “Note Field.” Click one of the fields on the upper right hand column to make your determination. Then press “submit.” If there are more videos in the queue, you will automatically be taken to the next one.



The Training

You’ll receive in person training via Zoom by a member of the Lead Stories TikTok team. You’ll be paid for your time, so make sure to clock your hours.

In addition to getting familiar with the tools we use to fact check including TCS, we'll go through the fact checking process, including how to make a determination, how to find fact checking resources, following guidelines, and helpful tips.

You'll complete a few sample fact checks during this process. You'll also be given several more fact checks to complete on your own that you will then share with editors before being given full access to our fact checking tools.

Please set aside an hour or two in your schedule for each training session.

The Fact Checking

- *Primary Sources*

Every fact check needs to be backed by sourced and verified facts. Whenever possible, we require the use of primary sources to support the conclusions in your determinations. Before citing other independent fact checking networks, please check the fact check archives at LeadStories.com - the reporting team might have already covered what you're looking for.

- *Objectivity*

We are committed to non-partisanship and fairness. You might not personally like the content you see, but you must remain objective. We are in the business of verifying information, not changing minds or being entertaining. Please avoid using biased language in your fact checks.

- *Timeliness*

The more fact checks you do, the less time they will take. Avoid going down a fact check rabbit hole.

- *Vigilance*

Be vigilant about video or photo content that you suspect is altered. Make sure your sources are from credible publications and organizations

- *Reporting*

Twice a month you will be responsible for compiling emerging and viral trends from the content you're fact checking in your region and submitting it in a report to editors. You'll receive instructions on how to complete the report in a separate email.

The Russia-Ukraine Conflict

Misinformation skyrockets during all rapidly developing situations and news events. The current Russia-Ukraine conflict is no different. Extra vigilance and scrutiny is needed to fact check and verify claims related to the conflict. This can sometimes include reverse image searches, geolocations, as well as verification of sources that could fall into the realm of propaganda and disinformation campaigns.

When videos feature content from Sputnik or RT, Russia's primary state media outlets that produce content in English, the fact check needs to include this identification. This is also true when the content includes information from TASS or RIA Novosti.

Please see this report on TikTok's policy related to Russian State media.

There are a variety of fact checking tools to help you verify content from this conflict (outlined under "Fact Checking Tools.") On the Lead Stories editorial side, our reporters are also actively debunking information and the articles published there are a valuable source of information. We suggest taking a look at this work to help you in your fact checks and also get a sense of the process our reporters use to verify claims. Some examples include:

Old Images of Jet Crashes Do NOT show downed 'Ghost of Kyiv'

WWII CGI Animation Does NOT Show February 2022 Conflict in Ukraine

Video Does NOT Show Russian and Ukrainian Armies Fightings - It's 2004 Iraq War

Supporting Links

Documenting and debunking dubious footage from Ukraine's frontlines

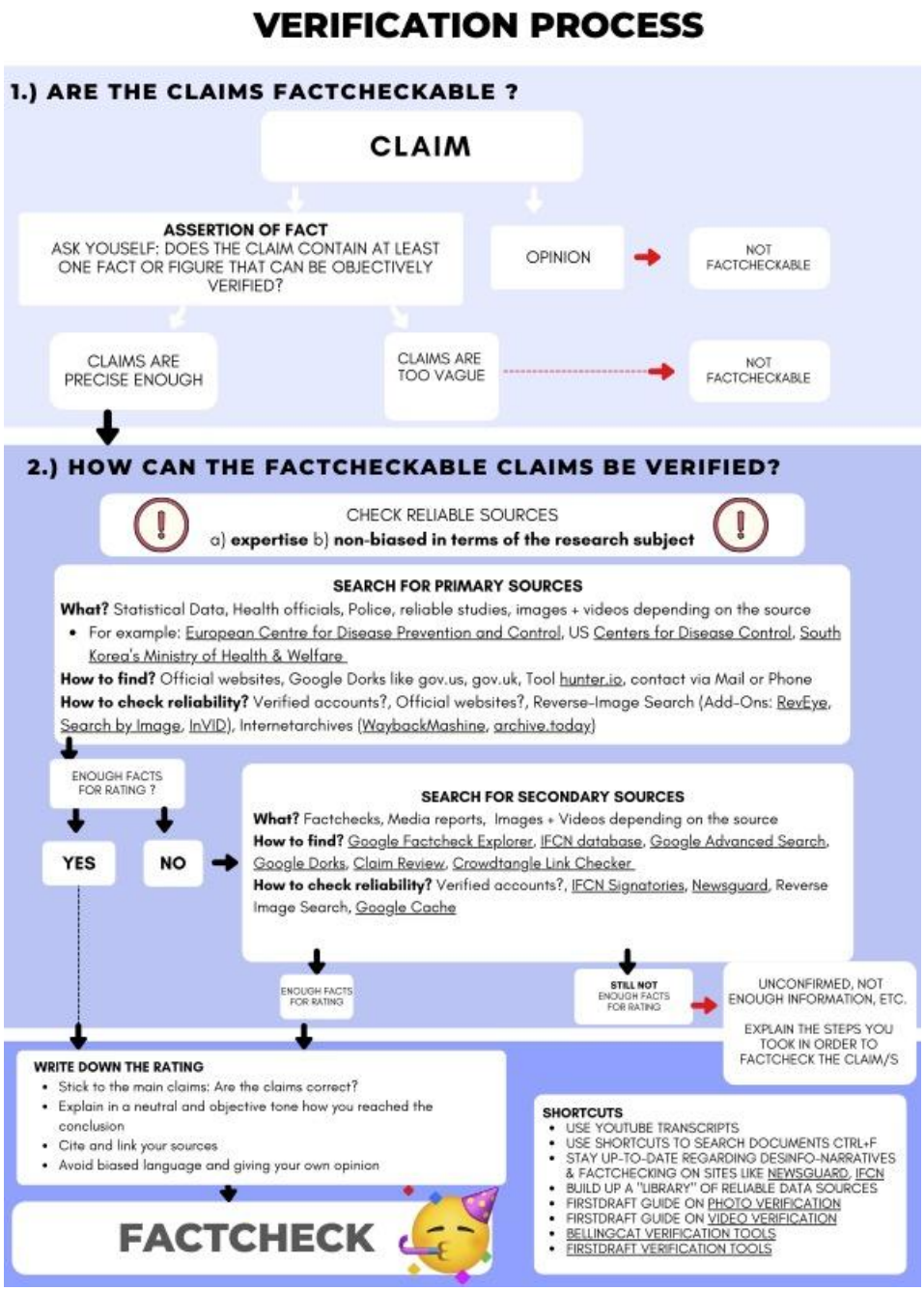
How to not report on Russian disinformation

War via TikTok: Russia's new tool for propaganda machine

Watch out for these 6 hoaxes about Russia's invasion of Ukraine

A guide to media and journalism in Russia

Working with traumatic imagery



The Fact Checking Process, Visualized

The Fact Checking Tools

- **EXIF Data** - See the metadata of an image file
- **InVid Plug-in** - Video analysis tool that gives you contextual information of a Youtube, Facebook or Twitter video to determine if it's real or fake
- **TinEye** - Reverse image search engine
- **RevEye** - Reverse image search plug-in
- **Hoaxy** - Online tool to help you visualize the spread of claims

The Questions to Ask Yourself

- Where did this content originate from?
- Who created the original content?
- When was it made? Upload times can differ from when a video was created
- Can you find the location of the content? Is it geotagged? Does the location make sense when you verify it?
- What was the intent and/or motivation of the source who created and disseminated the content?

The Resources

- **How Lead Stories Works**
- **TikTok's Community Guidelines**
- **How to Fact Check Like a Pro**
- **The International Fact Checking Network's Code of Principles**
- **Check the Credibility of Your Sources With NewsGuard**
- **Use Wayback Machine to Find Information in the Archive of the Internet**
- **Finding Clues to Geolocate an Image**
- **Verifying the Upload Date of a Video, Picture or Post in Facebook, Twitter, and Instagram**

The Contacts

It's always better to ask than to assume. Lead Stories TikTok editors are available to answer any questions you may have or guide you through a fact check you're unsure about. You can reach us at the following email addresses:

Chelsea - chelsea@leadstories.com
Liana - liana@leadstories.com
Raffaella - raffaella@leadstories.com